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My children

My first child was a boy who died seven days after he was born. I selected the name Muhammad for him. As you know, it is our custom to slaughter a small sheep or goat on the seventh day after a birth, which we called the Sebu. We invited the neighbors to eat bread soup (*fatta*). Even though my son died on the day of his Sebu, I did not inform the neighbors, and I let them go on with the preparations. Even my wife did not know. She was busy cooking. After the noon prayer, people came to my house to eat and to celebrate. I pretended that nothing had happened, and after lunch and tea I said, "Let us go to the grave and bury my son." I did this because I knew it was destiny for my son. I knew people were planning to come, so why should I spoil it with news of his death. In a matter of this type I was influenced by the sheikhs of the Muslim Brotherhood, who taught us that we should accept death with full satisfaction.

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But as soon as I gave this news, chaos reigned. My wife screamed and the women began putting mud on their heads. All the Nubian death customs were revived, and it was out of my control. One thing that made the grief more severe was that it was a male child who died. I don't believe in the superiority of males, but the villagers, and especially the women, still maintain this idea. Even now, people joke with me and call me "you father of girls." A man who can only father girls is regarded as inferior. People pity him. This is because girls cause great trouble. A man likes to have his male line carried on. Girls

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are a burden. They are attached to their home from birth until marriage, and actually their father is responsible for them as long as they live. When they marry they go to the home of their in-laws, but if divorce occurs they have to come back to their father's house and he is again solely responsible for them. Male children are a good means of support for their parents as long as they live. They keep the line alive and they keep the house of their father open.

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For all of my children, I am the only one who usually names the child, and my wife accepts. But I never force my will if she disagrees. I usually select names from the Koran or take the names of famous religious figures. The way I selected the name of my last daughter, Marium, was by opening the Koran randomly and picking a suitable name from that page.

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When I had my first child I had not been here in the village too long, and I noticed that the customs here were much different from what I used to see in Cairo. Here I found all the people coming to congratulate me, and all the women came to help and share with preparations according to their ability. Also, the people who came to congratulate were not satisfied with only having one soft drink and dates; they wanted to eat. The midwife was a Kenuz called Mabruka Galeya.

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